

to please are not the ones who are vocally against it. In fact this huge majority – the supposed recipient of this aid – is without a voice. Ironically the one thing that will give them this digital voice is being denied to them. Instead the already connected vocal minority – privileged internet-connected people like you and I – are the ones screaming ourselves hoarse on social media. Since it was a foreign news source you can forgive them for their lack of understanding of the nuances of this issue but at least people living here should be open minded enough. There are certain detractors of Free Basics who even go so far as to criticize the platform for not having JavaScript. That's just absurd.

Think of a restaurant that starts offering free dal roti to anyone who wants it. A bunch of underprivileged people start having this free meal. It's not stale or unpalatable, but it's just very basic dal and roti. How correct is it for you to ask, "Why aren't you feeding those poor people butter chicken and butter naan?" Actually, it's more like you demanding that they be fed a buffet dinner fit for kings, and by using someone else's money at that. And if they can't be fed according to your standards, well, then they should go hungry. How incredibly caring you are! Oversimplification you say? Well, sometimes it helps to simplify in order to understand. The bottom line is, we have no idea what the masses want, and we certainly don't know what they need.

Want a simple test of who you're really worried about? Think about the government asking ISPs to provide free (full) internet to everyone, and allowing them to recover those costs from existing users. Since millions seem to care so much for those people, and giving them the "real" internet, surely just voluntary donations of money, or halving your bandwidth would allow at least another 300 million Indians to come online. Are you willing to sacrifice something? If your answer is no, then you really should stop lying about caring for the welfare of Ganesh the farmer.

Another popular argument is that that Facebook will forever taint the

understanding of the next billion who come online. For them, Facebook will be synonymous with the internet. In fact, it's stated that a large section of the connected population already thinks this. I really need to Google this fact to find out if it's true. Oh sorry, I meant I need to search and find out if it's true. See what I did there? The starting point for many people already is Google. You have probably heard some friends say, "I read it on Google". No they didn't!

Here's another analogy: if I am a philanthropist shirt maker, and I give away my brand of shirts to an impoverished population of tribals, and they start thinking that all shirts are like this,



or even worse, they start thinking all "clothing" means this shirt, what is so terrible here? Would you rather they stay naked and exposed to the elements? Insert a certain type of food, say Cerelac being fed to impoverished babies in the above example instead of clothing to help drive the point home.

After adhering to certain regulations even pharma companies can distribute their brand of drug to an impoverished or calamity hit population. Should we let them suffer with fever rather than risk the horror of them thinking that all paracetamol is crocin?

No one is stupid enough to suggest that Free Basics shouldn't have guidelines and regulatory frameworks within which to operate. They certainly should.

But banning something is a totalitarian move. There is some good to be derived out of Free Basics and we should strive to maximize that by formulating a water tight policy.

BUT WE'LL ALL GET CONNECTED ANYWAY IN A FEW YEARS

One of the current arguments is that 100 million new internet users came online last year alone. It remains to be seen what demographic these connections came from and till what point the trend will continue to saturation without any change in policy. It's not a correlation or causation enough to say that the trend will continue

even if no change in pricing comes about. And even if it does, if you can boost the numbers with another solution, why deprive someone whose turn hasn't yet come?

Free Basics isn't a perfect solution, far from it. What we often fail to realise is that it's just a stop gap arrangement. It's not a solution that India deserves, but it's the one we have for now. Is Facebook stopping anyone else from finding a better way? If someone does offer a better way, won't the masses accept that willingly? It took a Reliance to drop costs of mobile telephony in India. Did they get rich doing so? Obviously. Did it help? Yes. Should they have not been allowed to implement their

disruption because people resented the fact that they would get rich doing so? You answer that...

But... but... Zuckerberg is evil!

Perhaps. None of us know that.

Is Free Basics really charity? Maybe. Do we believe that helping people is Zuckerberg's only true objective? Of course not! However, conscientious self interest is one of the fundamental pillars upon which the modern wave of internet giants have flourished. Do you seriously believe that, say, Google doesn't care about its share prices? So what separates this ideology from pure self interest? A notion that uplifting oneself inherently involves uplifting people at large, and thereby serving your own interest as well as others'.